

Lynx

Old, But Still *Fresh*

A CLI-based browser? Whatever for? Are you still in the early 90s? You may pose all these questions, but the truth is that Lynx, a CLI-based browser, is the favourite of many.

It was once the trusted friend of the visually-impaired—thanks to its text-to-speech friendly interface. But with the advent of better screen readers, Lynx lost some of its regular users (even as some got befuddled!).

You may continue to wonder why people are still using it. Before I elaborate on that, let me show some of its features. In this browser, you can click on a new link by highlighting a chosen link and selecting it. In one of my customised Lynx browsers, I have the freedom to enter the number of the link, as all the links are identified by number.

Support for SSL and many HTML features has been added in the recent versions. Here, the tables in a Web page are linearised. And, just like in Firefox, you have the freedom to view frames as separate pages (in fact, all the frames are identified by names). I am sure that if you haven't been exposed to Lynx, you must be thinking about the non-text content. Lynx can handle these contents by aptly launching an external program for viewing the respective contents—say an image viewer or video player.

Lynx was the brainchild of Lou Montulli, Michael Grobe and Charles Rezac of the University of Kansas (and Thomas Dickey maintains the package now). They brought out the browser way back in 1992. Though it was originally conceived for UNIX and VMS, it is still a popular console-based browser on Linux and is available along with many distros. Figure 1 shows Lynx in Kubuntu.

All the recent versions even run on Windows and Mac OSX (but for Mac there is a 'classical version'

available—MacLynx!). Please refer to the box for the complete list of platforms on which it has been tested.

Why Lynx?

Now I shall provide you with the reasons why people are still after *this* open-source, text-only Web browser and

Lynx has been tested in:

- AIX 3.2.5 (cc w/ curses)
- BeOS 4.5 (GCC w/ ncurses)
- CLIX (cc w/ curses & ncurses)
- DGUX
- Digital Unix 3.2C and 4.0 (GCC & cc w/ curses, ncurses & slang)
- FreeBSD 2.1.5, 3.1 (GCC 2.6.3 w/ curses & ncurses)
- HP-UX (K&R and ANSI cc, GCC w/ curses, ncurses & slang)
- IRIX 5.2 and 6.2 (cc & GCC w/ curses, ncurses & slang)
- Linux 2.0.0 (GCC 2.7.2 w/ curses, ncurses & slang)
- MLinux 2.1.5 (GCC 2.7.2.1)
- NetBSD
- NEXTSTEP 3.3 (GCC 2.7.2.3 w/ curses)
- OS/2 EMX 0.9c (ncurses)
- SCO OpenServer (cc w/ curses)
- Solaris 2.5, 2.6 & 2.7 (cc & GCC w/ curses, ncurses & slang)
- SunOS 4.1 (cc w/ curses, gcc w/ ncurses & slang)
- OS390 and BS2000